

Gaming interrupted

See if you can relate to this story: a teenage kid comes home from school. Soon as he enters the door a nagging mom follows a trail of discarded clothes leading up to a PC. Her voice gets drowned out by the staccato notes of machine gun fire coming from a pair of tiny Creative CS46 speakers. Remember those white boxy things with a grey grille? Even those gave that kid sitting at his 486 computer some major thrills. Between shooting Nazis on an obscenely bulging 14-inch "colour" CRT and making a very pixelated Prince jump through meat cutters, the kid absentmindedly keeps up a steady drone of "Yes mom, yes mom", "I'll do it later mom."

If you haven't figured it out already, that little kid is me.

Back then gaming was what my life was centered around. Everything was a calculated step towards more gaming. Everything from school, to sleep and even... er... other bodily functions revolved around this activity. I played every game that came bundled with Digit CDs – everything from Homeworld, Battlezone, Heretic and AOE to even NFS and Twisted Metal emulated on Bleem. The very first hotmail email account I made had an AOE cheatcode as the password. This was in an era when most kids my age would have their crush's name as their password.

I was so obsessed with gaming at one point of time, I not only wanted to play games but also create them, test them, maybe even live them (it's possible, think ARGs). In the early days of dial up internet, I hunted down undergraduate courses for game design abroad and even procured an offer letter from Penn State University. Without the proper direction (and maybe even gumption) that plan quickly fizzled out. But the gaming obsession didn't die.

Around 2002 I had to take a break from gaming in order to attend to some pressing matters such as studies, building character and you know, real life. Nah, who am I kidding? It was actually a forced sabbatical because I couldn't keep up with the upgrade race. But I never lost touch with technology. Even if I couldn't afford them I always tried to keep up with the latest and greatest in the technology space – particularly hardware. In the glossy pages of Digit I saw Voodoo² and

RIVA TNTs transition to GeForce and saw CRTs flatten to panels that eventually bulged the other way.

After joining Digit in late 2008, I found myself surrounded by all this glorious hardware, which until then, I only encountered in print. Best of all I got a chance to return to my obsession – gaming. Thankfully even Digit was stuck in a bygone era when it came to gaming. Guys here were playing Quake III of all the things! Like riding a bike, it all came back to me. Slowly the neurons re-established their connections, muscle memory awakened and soon I was not exactly kicking ass but getting reasonably good.

Cut to 2010 and I planned my triumphant return to gaming with my brand new Phenom II X2 555 BE (cores unlocked) and HD 5670 PC. But that didn't go as planned. I'm going to use a popular meme to explain why. It goes something like this:

I have a job so I'm able to buy video games.

Can't play video games because I have a job.

In my case, it was more like I have a job so I can buy hardware. (Who thought of "buying" games in this part of the world in those days anyway?). What's ironic though is in my particular job even if my work PC screen suddenly flickers on to Far Cry 4 in the middle of the day, no one bats an eyelid.

The more I look back and reminisce of the days gone by, the more I think about how people let go of their obsessions or passions along the way. Only sometimes, like with me, you end up doing a job where your passion and obsession can merge (if you can find the time that is!).

So that's been my gaming story. Do you have an interesting one too?



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A handwritten signature in black ink.

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